PEW RESEARCH CENTER NEWS INTEREST INDEX
DECEMBER 15-18, 2011
FINAL TOPLINE
N=1,004

ASK ALL:

PEW.1 As I read a list of some stories covered by news organizations this past week, please tell me if you happened to follow each news story very closely, fairly closely, not too closely, or not at all closely. First, **[INSERT ITEM; RANDOMIZE;] [IF NECESSARY** "Did you follow **[ITEM]** very closely, fairly closely, not too closely or not at all closely?"**]**

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
a. Reports about the condition of the U.S. economy					
December 15-18, 2011	36	32	14	16	1
December 8-11, 2011	41	29	13	16	1
December 1-4, 2011	40	33	13	13	1
November 17-20, 2011	35	33	16	15	1
November 10-13, 2011	39	31	15	14	*
November 3-6, 2011	37	31	15	17	1
October 27-30, 2011	38	33	14	15	1
October 20-23, 2011	38	32	14	16	1
October 13-16, 2011	39	32	14	14	*
October 6-9, 2011	43	28	14	14	1
September 29-October 2, 2011	46	26	14	14	*
September 22-25, 2011	44	33	11	11	*
September 8-11, 2011	40	30	15	14	1
September 1-4, 2011	44	30	11	15	*
August 25-28, 2011	44	28	14	13	1
August 18-21, 2011	44	29	12	14	1
August 4-7, 2011	46	30	11	13	1
July 28-31, 2011	43	30	13	13	*
July 21-24, 2011	41	32	13	13	1
July 14-17, 2011	41	30	14	14	1
July 7-10, 2011	36	30	15	18	1
June 30-July 3, 2011	38	32	13	16	1
June 23-26, 2011	37	29	15	19	*
June 16-19, 2011	39	33	14	13	*
June 9-12, 2011	39	30	15	16	1
June 2-5, 2011	35	34	17	14	*
May 19-22, 2011	33	34	17	16	*
May 12-15, 2011	32	32	17	18	2
May 5-8, 2011	40	35	15	9	1
April 21-25, 2011	41	33	12	14	*
April 14-17, 2011	44	30	14	12	1
April 7-10, 2011	46	30	14	10	*
March 31-April 3, 2011	42	31	16	11	0
March 24-27, 2011	36	32	17	15	*
March 17-20, 2011	38	32	17	13	*
March 10-13, 2011	40	30	16	13	*
March 3-6, 2011	37	31	17	13	1
February 24-27, 2011	49	29	11	10	*
February 17-20, 2011	35	33	14	17	*
February 10-13, 2011	36	34	13	16	*
February 3-6, 2011	35	37	14	14	*
January 20-23, 2011	37	33	14	15	1
January 13-16, 2011	37	29	15	18	1
January 6-9, 2011	39	37	11	12	1

SEE TRENDS FOR PREVIOUS YEARS

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
b. Political protests in Russia					
December 15-18, 2011	6	12	24	57	1
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
July 31-August 3, 2009: *The Iranian government's crackdown on opposition protestors*	18	23	26	31	2
July 2-5, 2009: *News about controversy surrounding the recent Iranian election*	22	31	23	23	*
June 26-29, 2009: *The Iranian government's crackdown on election protestors*	31	27	18	23	1
June 19-22, 2009: *Protests in Iran over disputed elections*	28	28	21	22	1
June 12-15, 2009: *The presidential election in Iran*	18	26	23	34	*
March 7-10, 2008: *The election of a new president in Russia*	7	18	23	51	1
December 7-10, 2007: *Recent parliamentary elections in Russia*	5	14	22	58	1
January 2000: *The resignation of Russian President Boris Yeltsin*	11	32	33	22	2
September 1999: *Political instability in Russia*	9	23	34	33	1
September 1998: *Economic and political instability in Russia*	18	30	28	24	*
Late August 1998: *Economic problems in Russia*	8	22	29	41	*
July 1996: *The Russian presidential elections*	7	25	31	37	*
January 1994: *The Russian elections*	11	32	31	26	*
October 1993: *Boris Yeltsin's conflict with the Russian parliament*	19	36	24	20	1
September 1993: *Boris Yeltsin's decision to dissolve the Russian parliament*	18	32	27	22	1
September 1993: *The political and economic changes going on in Russia*	12	36	29	22	*
April 1993: *The voter referendum in Russia*	10	20	36	32	2
January 1992: *Mikhail Gorbachev's resignation as the Soviet Union came to an official end*	31	42	20	7	*
December 1991: *The end of Mikhail Gorbachev's rule, as a new commonwealth was formed to replace the Soviet Union*	30	36	19	15	*
October 1991: *The breakup of the Soviet Union following the failed coup to depose Mikhail Gorbachev*	47	32	12	8	1
July 1991: *Russian President Boris Yeltsin's election victory and visit to the U.S.*	12	28	33	26	1
c. Congress working on a budget agreement to avoid a government shutdown					
December 15-18, 2011	27	23	21	29	1
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
November 10-13, 2011: *A "super committee" whose goal is to significantly reduce the federal budget deficit*	19	21	24	36	1
November 3-6, 2011: *Discussions in Washington about how to address the federal budget deficit and national debt*	24	31	21	24	1

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	(VOL.) DK/Ref
October 27-30, 2011	25	28	21	25	1
October 13-16, 2011: *The debate in Washington over jobs and the deficit*	29	32	15	24	1
September 29-October 2, 2011: *Congress working on a budget extension to avoid a government shutdown*	31	26	20	22	*
September 22-25, 2011: *The debate in Washington over jobs and the deficit*	35	26	19	19	1
September 15-18, 2011: *The debate in Washington over President Obama's jobs legislation*	31	28	19	21	2
September 8-11, 2011: *Barack Obama's speech about jobs to a joint session of Congress*	28	18	17	36	1
July 28-31, 2011: *Discussions in Washington about how to address the federal budget deficit and national debt*	41	27	15	17	*
July 21-24, 2011	38	28	17	17	*
July 14-17, 2011	34	29	18	19	*
June 16-19, 2011: *Debate in Washington over whether to raise the federal debt limit*	24	26	22	28	*
June 2-5, 2011	23	24	22	31	*
May 26-29, 2011: *Discussions in Washington about how to address the federal budget deficit*	25	26	20	29	*
May 12-15, 2011	21	26	24	28	1
May 5-8, 2011: *Discussions in Washington about how to address the federal budget deficit and national debt*	29	28	22	20	1
April 21-25, 2011	30	31	18	21	*
April 14-17, 2011	36	27	18	19	1
April 7-10, 2011: *The threat of a government shutdown because of budget disagreements in Washington*	47	26	15	12	*
March 31-April 3, 2011: *Discussions in Washington about how to address the federal budget deficit*	30	27	21	22	*
March 17-20, 2011	24	25	24	26	1
March 3-6, 2011	26	29	19	26	1
February 17-20, 2011	27	30	17	25	1
December 2-5, 2010	35	25	21	17	2
December 2-5, 2010: *The debate in Washington over the federal income tax cuts passed when George W. Bush was president*	39	26	17	17	1
November 11-14, 2010: *Proposals made by leaders of the federal budget deficit commission*	15	21	21	41	1
September 16-19, 2010: *The debate in Washington over competing Democratic and Republican tax plans*	21	24	21	34	*
September 9-12, 2010	16	19	22	42	1
May 8-11, 2009: *The debate in Washington over the federal budget*	22	28	19	31	*
March 27-30, 2009: *Debate over Barack Obama's budget proposal*	28	34	18	19	1
March 6-9, 2009: *Obama proposing a $630 billion fund for overhauling health care*	41	32	13	14	*

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
February 27-March 2, 2009: *Barack Obama's budget proposal for next year that raises taxes on wealthy Americans and increases spending on health care, education and other programs*	47	34	9	10	*
February 27-March 2, 2009: *The Obama administration's plan to help homeowners facing foreclosure which could cost as much as $275 billion dollars*	31	36	19	13	1
February 20-23, 2009: *The $780 billion economic stimulus legislation approved by Congress and signed into law by President Obama*	41	37	14	8	*
February 13-16, 2009: *Congress passing Barack Obama's economic stimulus plan*	50	32	13	5	*
February 6-9, 2009: *The debate in Congress over Barack Obama's economic stimulus plan*	41	33	15	11	*
January 30-February 2, 2009	36	29	22	13	*
January 16-19, 2009: *Debate in Washington over what the government should do about the nation's economic problems*	35	33	17	15	*
January 9-12, 2009: *Projections of a record high federal budget deficit this year*	35	30	19	16	*
December 19-22, 2008: *The Bush administration's plan to provide billions in emergency loans to U.S. automakers*	37	33	16	13	1
December 12-15, 2008: *The debate over a government bailout for the U.S. auto industry*	40	33	18	9	*
December 5-8, 2008: *The debate in Congress over a government bailout for the U.S. auto industry*	34	38	17	11	*
November 21-24, 2008	41	26	17	15	1
October 3-6, 2008: *The debate in Washington over a plan to use government funds to stabilize financial markets*	62	26	7	5	*
September 26-29, 2008	60	22	10	8	*
September 12-15, 2008: *The federal government taking control of the mortgage companies Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac*	28	35	19	17	1
March 20-24, 2008: *The buyout of Wall Street investment bank Bear Stearns*	21	26	21	32	*
February 8-11, 2008: *President Bush and Congress agreeing on an economic Stimulus plan*	22	33	23	21	1
January 25-28, 2008	24	36	19	21	*
February, 2003: *George W. Bush's tax cut and economic stimulus plan*	26	33	23	16	2
February, 2003	26	33	23	16	2
January, 2003	28	34	21	15	2
February, 2002: *The debate in Congress over George W. Bush's budget and tax cut plan*	17	31	28	23	1
April, 2001	24	38	20	18	*
February, 2001: *George W. Bush's tax cut plan*	31	35	19	14	1

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
August, 1997: *The debate in Washington about the federal budget*	14	34	25	26	1
May, 1997	16	38	23	22	1
February, 1997	19	28	22	29	2
March, 1996	24	35	23	18	*
January, 1996	32	42	17	9	*
September, 1995	20	35	27	18	*
August, 1995: *The debate in Congress over the federal budget*	18	34	27	20	1
February, 1995: *The debate in Congress over the Balanced Budget Amendment*	12	31	28	28	1
August, 1993: The debate in Congress over Bill Clinton's budget bill	30	36	21	13	*
June, 1993	12	38	31	18	1
February, 1993: *Bill Clinton's economic plan*	49	36	10	5	*
September, 1992 *(RV)*: *George Bush's plan to improve the economy by cutting government spending and cutting taxes*	28	44	18	9	1
November, 1990: *Congressional and administration efforts to reach a budget deficit agreement*	34	33	20	11	2
October, 1990: *Attempts by Congress and the administration to find ways to reduce the budget deficit*	34	37	17	12	*
August, 1989: *Passage of a bill to bailout ailing savings and loan institutions*	26	30	20	23	1
d. The complete withdrawal of U.S. forces from Iraq					
December 15-18, 2011	34	32	18	14	2
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
October 21-23, 2011: *President Obama announcing a complete withdrawal of U.S. forces from Iraq by the end of 2011*	30	30	19	20	1
December 16-19, 2010: *The current situation and events in Iraq*	19	30	27	24	*
September 2-6, 2010: *The withdrawal of U.S. combat troops from Iraq*	36	37	15	11	*
August 26-29, 2010: *The current situation and events in Iraq*	25	36	24	15	1
August 19-22, 2010: *The withdrawal of U.S. combat troops from Iraq*	31	33	19	17	1
August 5-8, 2010: *The current situation and events in Iraq*	23	35	22	18	1
May 13-16, 2010	31	34	21	13	2
March 12-15, 2010	22	36	28	14	*
March 5-8, 2010	26	34	20	20	*
January 29-February 1, 2010	23	33	27	17	*
January 15-18, 2010	20	35	28	17	*
October 16-19, 2009	23	30	24	23	*
September 11-14, 2009	21	33	30	16	*
August 21-24, 2009	25	35	22	18	1
August 14-17, 2009	19	38	23	18	*
July 2-5, 2009: *U.S. troops withdrawing from Iraqi cities*	25	34	20	21	0
April 24-27, 2009: *The current situation and events in Iraq*	21	35	25	19	*
March 20-23, 2009	25	37	21	17	*

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
February 27-March 2, 2009: *Barack Obama's plan to withdraw most U.S. troops from Iraq by August 2010*	40	37	13	9	1
December 12-15, 2008: *The current situation and events in Iraq*	24	35	25	16	*
November 21-24, 2008	32	31	24	13	0
November 14-17, 2008	24	33	27	16	*
October 31-November 3, 2008	30	35	22	12	1
October 24-27, 2008	29	35	25	11	*
October 10-13, 2008	23	34	30	13	*
October 3-6, 2008	29	33	28	10	*
September 5-8, 2008	24	37	26	13	*
August 29-31, 2008	22	32	29	16	1
August 22-25, 2008	26	31	27	15	1
August 1-4, 2008	27	40	23	10	*
July 25-28, 2008	28	33	22	17	*
July 18-21, 2008	33	35	20	12	*
July 11-14, 2008	24	35	24	16	1
July 3-7, 2008	25	35	25	15	*
June 20-23, 2008	25	36	24	15	*
May 9-12, 2008	29	35	21	14	1
May 2-5, 2008	26	35	25	13	1
April 25-28, 2008	29	35	23	12	1
April 18-21, 2008	29	39	20	11	1
April 11-14, 2008	25	39	20	15	1
April 4-7, 2008	25	37	23	15	*
March 28-31, 2008	29	40	19	11	1
March 20-24, 2008	30	38	19	13	*
March 14-17, 2008	29	38	23	10	*
March 7-10, 2008	28	39	18	15	*
February 29-March 3, 2008	28	40	19	13	*
February 8-11, 2008	24	35	25	16	*
February 1-4, 2008	28	39	22	11	*
January 25-28, 2008	23	35	26	16	*
January 18-21, 2008	31	33	20	15	1
January 11-14, 2008	25	38	21	16	*
January 4-7, 2008	27	38	20	15	*
December 14-17, 2007	26	32	24	18	*
December 7-10, 2007	28	37	21	14	*
November 23-26, 2007	25	37	21	16	1
November 16-19, 2007	31	37	19	12	1
November 9-12, 2007	29	38	19	13	1
November 2-5, 2007	31	35	18	15	1
October 26-29, 2007	28	37	21	13	1
October 19-22, 2007	28	37	20	15	*
October 12-15, 2007	26	36	18	19	1
October 5-8, 2007	29	33	22	16	*
September 28 – October 1, 2007	30	41	18	11	*
September 21-24, 2007	32	38	17	13	*
September 14-17, 2007	31	36	18	15	0
September 7-10, 2007	32	34	20	14	*
August 30 – September 2, 2007	31	34	18	16	1
August 24-27, 2007	34	36	18	12	*
August 17-20, 2007	33	34	18	15	*
August 10-13, 2007	36	37	14	13	*
August 3-6, 2007	29	40	19	12	*
July 27-30, 2007	28	36	19	16	1
July 20-23, 2007	28	34	21	16	1
July 13-16, 2007	25	41	17	16	1

PEW.1 CONTINUED...

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
July 6-9, 2007	36	34	18	12	*
June 29-July 2, 2007	32	35	19	13	1
June 22-25, 2007	30	36	18	15	1
June 15-18, 2007	30	37	20	13	*
June 8-11, 2007	32	38	15	14	1
June 1-4, 2007	30	36	20	13	1
May 24-27, 2007	33	36	18	12	1
May 18-21, 2007	36	34	15	14	1
May 11-14, 2007	30	34	18	17	1
May 4-7, 2007	38	37	15	10	*
April 27-30, 2007	27	35	21	16	1
April 20-23, 2007	28	35	22	15	*
April 12-16, 2007	34	33	20	13	*
April 5-9, 2007	33	39	16	11	1
March 30-April 2, 2007	34	37	16	13	*
March 23-March 26, 2007: *News about the current situation in Iraq*	31	38	18	12	1
March 16-19, 2007	34	34	17	15	*
March 9-12, 2007	34	37	16	13	*
March 2-5, 2007	37	37	16	9	1
February 23-26, 2007	36	36	15	13	*
February 16-19, 2007	30	36	19	14	1
February 9-12, 2007	37	34	18	11	*
February 2-5, 2007	38	38	17	7	*
January 26-29, 2007	36	38	15	11	*
January 19-22, 2007	37	34	18	10	1
January 12-15, 2007	38	36	17	8	1
January, 2007	46	40	8	5	1
January 5-8, 2007	40	32	16	12	0
December, 2006	42	39	12	7	*
November 30-December 3, 2006	40	36	13	11	*
Mid-November, 2006	44	38	12	6	*
September, 2006	33	43	14	8	2
August, 2006	41	39	12	7	1
June, 2006	37	43	13	6	1
May, 2006	42	35	15	7	1
April, 2006	43	36	13	7	1
March, 2006	43	38	12	6	1
February, 2006	39	42	12	6	1
January, 2006	40	40	12	7	1
December, 2005	45	38	11	5	1
Early November, 2005	41	40	13	6	*
Early October, 2005	43	36	15	6	*
Early September, 2005	32	40	20	7	1
July, 2005	43	37	13	6	1
Mid-May, 2005	42	42	11	5	*
Mid-March, 2005	40	39	14	5	2
February, 2005	38	45	13	4	*
January, 2005	48	37	11	4	*
December, 2004	34	44	15	6	1
Mid-October, 2004	42	38	11	8	1
Early September, 2004	47	37	9	6	1
August, 2004	39	42	12	6	1
July, 2004	43	40	11	6	*
June, 2004	39	42	12	6	1
April, 2004	54	33	8	5	*
Mid-March, 2004	47	36	12	4	1
Early February, 2004	47	38	10	4	1

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
Mid-January, 2004	48	39	9	4	*
December, 2003	44	38	11	6	1
November, 2003	52	33	9	5	1
September, 2003	50	33	10	6	1
Mid-August, 2003	45	39	10	5	1
Early July, 2003	37	41	13	8	1
June, 2003	46	35	13	6	*
May, 2003	63	29	6	2	*
April 11-16, 2003: *News about the war in Iraq*	47	40	10	2	1
April 2-7, 2003	54	34	9	2	1
March 20-24, 2003	57	33	7	2	1
March 13-16, 2003: *Debate over the possibility that the U.S. will take military action in Iraq*	62	27	6	4	1
February, 2003	62	25	8	4	1
January, 2003	55	29	10	4	2
December, 2002	51	32	10	6	1
Late October, 2002	53	33	8	5	1
Early October, 2002	60	28	6	5	1
Early September, 2002: *Debate over the possibility that the U.S. will invade Iraq*	48	29	15	6	2
e. A sex abuse scandal at Penn State University					
December 15-18, 2011	22	29	23	25	1
December 8-11, 2011	24	29	24	22	1
November 17-20, 2011: *A sex abuse scandal at Penn State University*	28	31	21	18	1
November 10-13, 2011: *A sex abuse scandal at Penn State University resulting in the firing of the school's president and football coach Joe Paterno*	34	29	19	18	1
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
August 18-21, 2011: *Recent scandals in college football*	10	12	17	61	*
September 16-19, 2010: *Pope Benedict's visit to Great Britain and his comments on the Catholic Church's handling of sex-abuse scandals*	10	16	26	47	1
April 23-26, 2010: *Reports about the Vatican's handling of sex-abuse scandals in the Catholic Church*	14	28	29	29	*
March 26-29, 2010	17	24	28	30	*
March 19-22, 2010	8	18	31	42	1
June, 2002: *Reports of sexual abuses by Catholic priests*	38	36	17	8	1
May, 2002: *The Pope and American cardinals meeting in Rome about sexual abuse by Catholic priests*	27	33	21	18	1
Early April, 2002: *Reports of sexual abuses by Catholic priests*	27	34	25	13	1
December, 1993	18	32	31	18	1
f. News about candidates for the 2012 presidential elections					
December 15-18, 2011	26	24	20	29	1
December 8-11, 2011	27	27	18	28	*
December 1-4, 2011	25	28	20	26	1
November 17-20, 2011	24	31	21	23	1

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
November 3-6, 2011	22	31	20	26	1
October 27-30, 2011	21	26	21	30	1
October 20-23, 2011	21	28	22	28	1
October 13-16, 2011	26	29	22	23	1
October 6-9, 2011	25	25	23	27	1
September 29-October 2, 2011	27	26	21	25	*
September 22-25, 2011	25	26	23	25	1
September 15-18, 2011	24	28	21	27	1
September 8-11, 2011	22	26	21	31	*
September 1-4, 2011	22	23	22	32	1
August 25-28, 2011	22	22	22	33	1
August 18-21, 2011	27	26	19	28	1
August 11-14, 2011	19	24	20	36	1
August 4-7, 2011	18	21	22	37	1
July 28-31, 2011	17	27	21	35	1
July 21-24, 2011	17	22	28	32	*
July 14-17, 2011	18	26	27	28	1
July 7-10, 2011	16	23	27	33	1
June 30-July 3, 2011	21	28	24	25	2
June 23-26, 2011	19	26	24	31	*
June 16-19, 2011	23	29	23	25	*
June 9-12, 2011	18	30	22	30	1
June 2-5, 2011	21	31	22	26	*
May 26-29, 2011	20	27	24	28	*
May 19-22, 2011	15	27	24	32	1
May 12-15, 2011	15	22	26	35	1
May 5-8, 2011	16	24	27	32	1
April 21-25, 2011	18	26	23	32	1
April 14-17, 2011	20	23	29	27	1
March 24-27, 2011	13	19	26	41	1
March 10-13, 2011	15	21	26	38	0
February 10-13, 2011	16	19	24	40	*
February 3-6, 2011	15	20	23	42	*

SEE TRENDS FOR PREVIOUS YEARS

ASK ALL:

PEW.2 Which ONE of the stories I just mentioned have you followed most closely, or is there another story you've been following MORE closely? [**DO NOT READ LIST. ACCEPT ONLY ONE RESPONSE.]**

Dec 15-18 2011	
18	Reports about the condition of the U.S. economy
17	News about candidates for the 2012 presidential elections
17	A sex abuse scandal at Penn State University
12	The complete withdrawal of U.S. forces from Iraq
8	Congress working on a budget agreement to avoid a government shutdown
1	Political protests in Russia
8	Some other story **(VOL.)**
20	Don't know/Refused **(VOL.)**